Chillai Kalan, the harshest period of winter in Kashmir. Would she be able to walk in such difficult circumstances?

Despite my reluctance, my mother dug in her heels. There was more to come. My daughter Iltija waded into the conversation. ‘Ma, I also want to walk with him.’

I was stumped. Rare are the occasions when I’m at a loss for words. I had little choice but to cave in. Having seen RG effortlessly stride through sub-zero temperatures in just a T-shirt, Mummy was concerned. The next day, as we joined him at Pulwama, there was already a sea of people surrounding us, spilling over both sides of the road. Perhaps it had a lot to do with the fact that this was the first time since 2019 that any national leader was among them and empathizing with their collective plight. As Mummy draped a muffler around his neck, it was accompanied by kisses. He, in turn, clutched her hand protectively.

And thus we began. Three generations of women from my family walking head-to-head with Rahul Gandhi. I’ve interacted with RG on previous occasions, but this time I saw a completely different side. Barely twenty minutes from the time we started, he could sense my mother’s discomfort as she gasped for air. Not wanting to risk it, he stopped and told his security to escort her back.

As we surged through, I caught the sight of elderly men and women on the other side gazing at RG with tender eyes. Perhaps they were reminiscing the times when Indira ji would frequently travel across the Valley waving at crowds.

Over the decades, national leaders have made perfunctory visits to Kashmir. But for the first time the Kashmiris found a familiar face walking among themselves. As RG and I started to talk about the distressing situation in Kashmir, we were often interrupted by people from all walks of life, who wanted to shake hands and take pictures with him. He readily obliged without even a trace of unease. Whether it was young men or women, senior citizens or children, each embraced him with an affection that filled the atmosphere with positive energy.